

Home Inspection in Texas: What New Braunfels Buyers Need to Know

A home inspection is your best tool for understanding what you're actually buying. Here's what inspectors check, what they miss, and how to turn findings into negotiating leverage in Comal County.

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The home inspection is one of the most important steps in buying a home in New Braunfels — and one of the most misunderstood. Buyers sometimes treat it as a box to check rather than a tool to use. Done right, the inspection period is your window into the real condition of the property, your opportunity to renegotiate if needed, and your last clear chance to walk away before you're fully committed. This guide explains what a Texas home inspection covers, what it doesn't, and how to turn your inspection report into actionable decisions.

WHAT AN INSPECTION COVERS

What a Texas Licensed Home Inspector Actually Checks

Home inspectors in Texas are licensed by the Texas Real Estate Commission and must follow a defined Standards of Practice that specifies exactly what must be inspected and reported. Understanding the scope of a standard inspection helps buyers know what questions to ask and where the inspector's findings are most likely to surface.

Structural and Foundation

The inspector evaluates the foundation type and visible condition — slab foundations are most common in New Braunfels, with pier-and-beam appearing in older and historic homes. In Central Texas, expansive clay soils cause foundation movement that is extremely common, and the inspector will note any visible signs of stress: cracks in brick veneer, doors or windows that stick, sloping floors, or gaps between walls and ceilings. A notation about foundation movement does not mean the home is unsound — it means further evaluation by a structural engineer may be warranted.

Roof, Attic, and Insulation

The inspector evaluates roof covering condition and remaining life expectancy, flashing at penetrations and transitions, gutters and drainage, and visible attic conditions including insulation depth, ventilation, and any signs of moisture intrusion or pest damage. In New Braunfels, where hail

events are common and roofs bear the brunt of Texas summers, roof condition is one of the most consequential findings. A roof needing replacement in the next one to three years is a material cost to factor into your offer or renegotiation.

Electrical, Plumbing, and HVAC

The electrical inspection covers the main panel, visible wiring, grounding, GFCI protection in wet areas, and the condition of outlets and switches. For plumbing, the inspector checks visible supply and drain lines, water heater age and condition, water pressure, and any signs of leaks. HVAC systems are operated and evaluated for age, condition, and basic function — in New Braunfels, where systems run hard for eight months of the year, an aging HVAC is one of the most common inspection findings and one of the most commonly negotiated items.

WHAT IT DOESN'T COVER

The Limits of a Standard Home Inspection

A standard home inspection is a visual evaluation by a generalist. It is not a code compliance inspection, a structural engineering assessment, a sewer scope, a pool inspection, a survey, or a guarantee of future performance. Understanding these limits helps buyers make informed decisions about when to bring in specialist inspectors.

What Requires a Separate Specialist

Several common and important inspection categories fall outside the general home inspection: foundation engineering assessment by a licensed structural engineer, sewer line scoping by a plumber using a camera, pool and spa inspection, chimney inspection, mold testing, and well flow rate and water quality testing for rural properties. Determining which specialty inspections your property warrants is a judgment call — your agent and general inspector can advise based on what the property is and what the general inspection reveals.

NEW BRAUNFELS SPECIFICS

Inspection Concerns Specific to New Braunfels and Comal County

Every market has its own common inspection issues shaped by local soil, climate, construction era, and building practices. New Braunfels and Comal County have several patterns that experienced local buyers and inspectors know to look for.

Foundation Movement from Expansive Soils

The clay-heavy soils of Central Texas expand when wet and contract when dry — a seasonal cycle that puts stress on slab foundations year after year. Visible signs of differential movement are present in a significant percentage of homes in the area. Most movement is cosmetic or manageable; some indicates more serious structural issues. When the inspection report mentions foundation concerns, investing \$300 to \$600 in a licensed structural engineer's evaluation is almost always worth it before committing to the purchase.

Termites and Wood-Destroying Insects

Central Texas has active termite pressure, and a Wood-Destroying Insect (WDI) report — sometimes called a termite inspection — is a separate inspection from the general home inspection, conducted by a licensed pest control company for \$75 to \$150. VA and FHA loans require a WDI report; conventional buyers are not required to obtain one but are well-advised to do so. Getting a WDI report on every purchase is a reasonable precaution given Comal County's termite activity.

HVAC Systems in a Texas Climate

Air conditioning systems in New Braunfels run continuously from April through October. A system approaching 15 years old in this climate is likely near end of life — replacement costs for a properly sized system run \$5,000 to \$12,000 depending on home size. Your inspector will report on age and apparent condition, but an HVAC-specific evaluation by a licensed contractor can provide more precise life expectancy and condition assessment.

Well and Septic for Rural and Canyon Lake Properties

Properties in the Canyon Lake area, River Chase, and rural Comal County often operate on private wells and septic systems. A well inspection should include a flow rate test and a certified lab water quality analysis. A septic inspection should assess the system type, current condition, last service date, and capacity relative to the home's bedroom count. Never skip these inspections — replacement costs for a failed well pump or septic system can run \$15,000 to \$40,000 or more.

READING THE REPORT

How to Read an Inspection Report Without Panicking

Inspection reports are written to document deficiencies. They are not written to contextualize those deficiencies or tell you whether the home is worth buying. A report on a well-maintained 10-year-old home can run 40 pages. The number of findings is not the measure of a home's condition — the nature and severity is.

Safety Items vs. Maintenance Items vs. Material Defects

Safety items — missing GFCI protection, inoperative smoke detectors, double-tapped breakers — should be addressed regardless of whether you negotiate them. Maintenance items — minor caulking, dirty filters — are the normal cost of homeownership and not typically negotiated. Material defects — foundation concerns, roofing at or near end of life, significant moisture intrusion — are the items worth discussing with your agent and potentially bringing back to the seller.

What Is Reasonable to Negotiate After an Inspection

Focus on material defects: items that represent significant cost, pose a safety concern, or reflect conditions the seller's disclosure did not accurately represent. Sellers will push back on requests that feel like cherry-picking minor maintenance. A narrow, well-supported repair request is more likely to result in a productive negotiation than a list of 30 items. Your agent will help you calibrate what's reasonable given the specific market conditions.

THE OPTION PERIOD

Using the Option Period to Your Advantage

The Texas option period is designed exactly for this purpose — to give buyers time and flexibility to conduct due diligence. Using it well is a skill.

- Schedule your inspector immediately after contract execution — the best inspectors book quickly.
- Order specialty inspections during the same window so all findings are in hand before the option period expires.
- Review the seller's disclosure notice carefully against the inspection report — inconsistencies are significant.
- Get your homeowner's insurance quote during the option period — roof age or prior claims may affect insurability.
- Obtain repair cost estimates for any major items you plan to negotiate — a contractor's bid is more credible than a round-number request.
- Give yourself at least 2 days before the option period ends to execute any amendment negotiations.

Frequently Asked Questions

How much does a home inspection cost in New Braunfels?

A standard general home inspection typically runs \$350 to \$600 for a home in the 1,500 to 3,000 square foot range. Larger homes or homes with pools cost more. A WDI (termite) inspection adds \$75 to \$150. Specialty inspections — structural engineering, sewer scope, pool, or well and septic — each run \$150 to \$450 depending on the service.

Should I attend my home inspection in person?

Yes, if at all possible. Walking through the home with the inspector in real time gives you context that a written report can't fully convey. For out-of-town buyers, ask the inspector to do a live video walkthrough — many inspectors in the area will accommodate this.

What are the most common inspection issues in New Braunfels homes?

Foundation movement from expansive clay soils is the most common finding and warrants the most careful follow-up. Roof condition — particularly hail damage and aging shingles — is consistently among the top findings. Aging HVAC systems, electrical issues in older homes, and plumbing concerns in pre-1990s properties round out the most common categories.

Can I negotiate repairs after the inspection in Texas?

Yes. After receiving your inspection report during the option period, your agent prepares an Amendment to Contract listing repairs or credits you're requesting. The seller can accept, counter, or decline. If you can't reach agreement and you're still within the option period, you can terminate and recover your earnest money.

Is a foundation issue a dealbreaker in New Braunfels?

Not necessarily. Cosmetic cracking and minor differential movement are extremely common in Central Texas. The right response is to hire a licensed structural engineer to evaluate severity, cause, and recommended remedy — a \$300 to \$600 investment that gives you real information before committing hundreds of thousands of dollars.

What is a WDI inspection and do I need one?

A WDI (Wood-Destroying Insect) report is conducted by a licensed pest control company and evaluates the property for termites, carpenter ants, and wood-boring beetles. VA and FHA lenders require one; conventional buyers are not required but are well-advised given the active termite pressure in Central Texas. Cost is typically \$75 to \$150.

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